AFTERWARDS

THOMAS HARDY

INTRODUCTION

Thomas Hardy (1840-1928) was one of the most outstanding English poets and novelists. Most of his poems display elements of English poetry found during the Romantic and Victorian periods. Initially Hardy was more well-known for his Wessex novels; his poems attracted renewed critical acclamation since the middle of the twentieth century, and now he is regarded as a major English poet of the twentieth century. Many of his poems deal with themes of disappointments in human lives and mankind's tragic encounters with suffering. In this poem, the poet anticipates his own death, and tries to understand how he will be remembered after his death. The beautiful references to the small details of nature in the poem tell us that he wants to be remembered as a man having an eye for the beauties of nature.

TEXT

When the Present has latched its postern behind my tremulous
stay,
And the May month flaps its glad green leaves like wings,
Delicate-filmed as new-spun silk, will the neighbours say,
'He was a man who used to notice such things'?

If it be in the dusk when, like on eyelid's soundless blink,
The dewfall hawk come crossing the shades to alight
Upon the wind-warped upland thorn, a gazer may think
'To him this must have been a familiar sight.'

If I pass during some natural blackness, mothy and warm,
When the hedgehog travels furtively over the lawn,
One may say, He strove that such innocent creatures should come to no harm,
But he could do little for them; and now he is gone.'

If, when hearing that I have been stilled at last, they stand at the door,
Watching the full starred heaven that winter sees,
Will this thought rise on those who will meet my face no more,
'He was one who had an eve for such mysteries'?

'And will any say when my bell of quittance is heard in the gloom,
And a crossing breeze cuts a pause in its outrollings,
Till they rise again, as they were new bell's boom,
'He hears it not now, but used to notice such things'?

Glossary/Notes

Latch: to fasten with a latch
Postern: a back door, used especially for private use
Tremulous: nervous or weak
Present has latched its postern: The end of life, because the entrance to the present is closed.
Tremulous stay: The poet says that human life is weak and vulnerable.
When the Present has latched its postern behind my tremulous stay: The poet thinks of the time after his death.
Dewfall hawk: In this poem it is a harbinger of death.
Alight: to come down from the air and settle down on something
Warped: twisted as a result of heat and damp
Uphill: hilly countryside
Gazer: onlooker
Nocturnal: happening in the night

Hedgehog: a small animal with stiff spines covering its back—out mostly during night
Furtively: secretly, in order to avoid others' attention
Bell of quittance: church bell announcing someone's death

COMPREHENSION

A. Answer these questions in about 20 words.

1. What is the time which the poet refers to?
2. How does a dewfall hawk alight?
3. Which time is described as mothy and warm?
4. Who travels furtively and where?
5. How does the sky appear during the winter?
6. How would the poet like to be remembered after his death?
7. What was a familiar sight to the poet?

B. Answer these questions in 50-60 words.

1. 'He was a man who used to notice such things'—Who is referred to here? What were the things that he used to notice?
2. Briefly comment on the title of the poem.